

Definition Drift Debate Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	definition-drift-debate

Big idea: Definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context.

Overview

Students trace how a key term changes across contexts and debate whether changing definitions change knowledge.

Student Prompt

Inspect Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Term: intelligence; definitions from test performance, adaptive behavior, creativity, social understanding, and problem-solving. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Definition Drift Debate Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Definition Drift Debate Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Definition Drift Debate Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Do definitions describe reality or help construct it?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how definitions stabilize inquiry, but they can also shift with purpose, power, and context.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Pick one term with genuine but manageable ambiguity.
- Use a specific purpose for the debate, such as school policy, research, classification, or exhibition commentary.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Term: intelligence; definitions from test performance, adaptive behavior, creativity, social understanding, and problem-solving.
- Term: art; definitions from intention, institution, skill, audience response, and originality.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Choose a term such as intelligence, health, art, risk, fairness, or success.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Groups receive different definitions and list what each definition includes and excludes.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students apply each definition to borderline examples.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Groups debate which definition is most useful for a specific purpose.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief how definitions can shape what evidence counts.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- A definition is doing work. What work is this definition doing?
- Which cases become easier or harder to know under this definition?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may say language merely expresses thought rather than shaping interpretation.
- Students may identify bias in extreme examples but miss subtle framing.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Explains how wording changes interpretation before evidence is judged.
- Uses concrete language choices as evidence for a TOK claim.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use two definitions and three cases.
- Challenge: ask students to identify power effects in definition choices.

Extension Tasks

- Students write a definition with a clear purpose and a named limitation.
- Compare definitions across two languages or institutions.

Related Activities

- Category Boundary Sorting
- Translation Loss Game
- Loaded Headline Laboratory